LUMINOSITIES

Omega Sagittarii *8 Suns* | Arkab Posterior *29 Suns* | Alnasl *49 Suns* | Rukbat *70 Suns*

# SAGITTARIUS

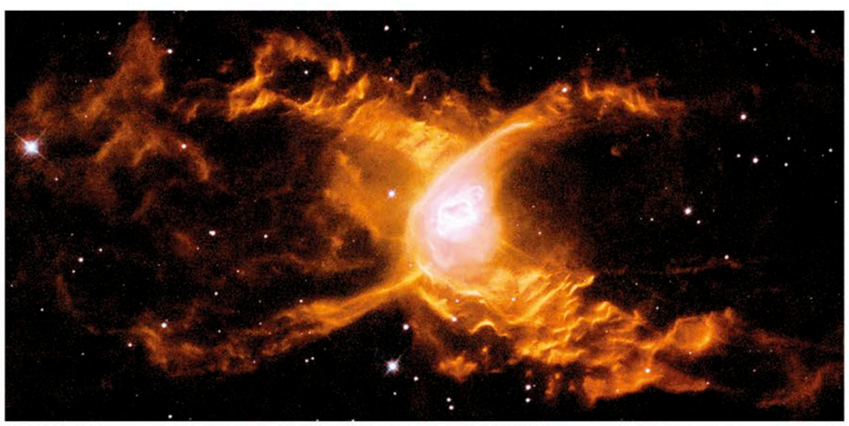
## THE ARCHER

**A LARGE ZODIACAL CONSTELLATION, SAGITTARIUS REPRESENTS A MYTHICAL CREATURE CALLED A CENTAUR, PART-MAN, PART-HORSE, HOLDING A BOW AND ARROW. IT LIES IN A RICH AREA OF THE MILKY WAY AND CONTAINS THE CENTER OF OUR GALAXY.**

Sagittarius is most easily identified by the teapotlike shape formed by its main stars'. The Teapot asterism is made up of eight stars. Zeta, Sigma, Tau, and Phi form the handle, Gamma, Delta, and Epsilon form the spout, and Lambda forms the top of the lid. The brightest star in the constellation is Epsilon, not Alpha, as is typically the case in other constellations. In Sagittarius, Alpha is magnitude 4.0, whereas Epsilon is magnitude 1.8.

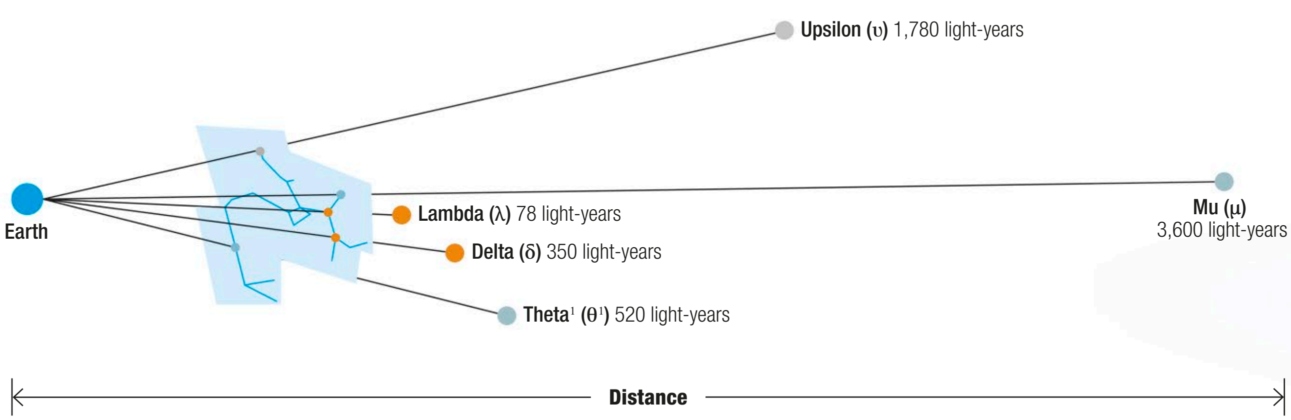
Sagittarius contains dense Milky Way star fields, because the center of our Galaxy lies in this direction. The exact center is marked by the radio source Sagittarius A*, thought to be the site of a supermassive black hole.

Charles Messier catalogued 15 objects in Sagittarius, more than in any of the other constellations. Notable examples include M8 (the Lagoon Nebula), M20 (the Trifid Nebula), and M22, a bright globular cluster.



◁ **Red Spider Nebula**
Huge waves sweep through NGC 6537, a spiderlike planetary nebula.The waves are caused by the expanding outer layers of the central star compressing and heating the surrounding interstellar gas.

▽ **Star distances**
Sagittarius's main pattern stars vary between 78 and about 3,600 light-years from Earth. The nearest, Lambda (λ) Sagittarii, forms the top of the lid of the Teapot asterism. As seen from Earth, Mu (μ) Sagittarii appears relatively close to Lambda but Mu is actually the constellation's most distant pattern star and is more than 3,500 light-years farther from Earth than is Lambda.




**Little Gem Nebula**
Also known as NGC 6818, a planetary nebula about half a light-year in diameter and lying about 6,000 light-years away